

EDUCATIONAL INSTITUTES TURNING TECH-SAVVY

What would classrooms look like in the near future? Will they continue with a teacher sitting in front of students telling them what to do or look altogether different? Explore

■ SUDESHNA DAS

Issac Asimov, renowned science fiction writer, once wrote of a future that included robotic teachers. The schoolgirl in his story 'The Fun They Had' comes home from the school and narrates the story of the robot teacher

in her school. Though it is not 'reality,' as the technology evolves, however, human teachers are keen to experiment with advanced technology to facilitate learning.

What are the possibilities in store for an institute that embraces technology? Endless! That's what we found after

hearing the discourse of industry experts at the Tech@Edu 2009 workshop. The speakers shared with the audience successful technology implementations, ideas of possible technology platforms and opinions on future technology usage. We reproduce here those insights into a futuristic educational ecosystem.

Classrooms of Tomorrow!

Cisco's mobile classroom concept

Institutes are moving away from the traditional desktop computer lab and integrating computers in the classroom as much as possible. But, this can be challenging when an institute has a limited budget, limited space or many students. Cabling is expensive—especially for an infrastructure constructed from bricks.

Wireless technology helps to solve these issues. Our wireless technology allows laptops on mobile carts to access the Internet or campus network, without connecting to a network cable or telephone line. Not only do these 'mobile classrooms' save space in a building but they also provide a better opportunity to integrate technology into the curriculum. By having the computers in the classroom, the faculty members are more likely to utilise technology for all their instructional programmes.

Wireless Internet connectivity can be used in other ways too, such as turning a common area like the lunchroom into an Internet café for students and faculty.



Lokesh Mehra
regional manager-corporate responsibility,
South Asia, Cisco Systems

VINYTICS' classroom teaching software

VINYTICS has made a beginning by developing classroom teaching software for hardware equipment, learning tools and concept-building applications. This software consists mainly of two parts, simulator and tutorial. The first part gives step-by-step demo of the equipment and the second part imparts the theoretical knowledge about the equipment.



Vinod Verma
managing director,
Vinytics Peripherals

Virtual classrooms

Marksman has introduced a product called BuzzBoard with inbuilt Web 2.0 features. It is secure and scalable, and can be integrated with any third-party software and application. BuzzBoard is a virtual platform for distance education and can be used for virtual classrooms and real-time interactive learning. It connects subject matter experts and learners in real time. Also, BuzzBoard archives all the teaching sessions.



Vishal Bisht
CEO, Marksman Technologies

Evidence of problem-solving transfer in Web-based tutor

This study involved students from the fall 2003 semester taking the introductory Newtonian mechanics course at the Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT). The students (430 in total) were divided into two equally skilled groups based on their MasteringPhysics homework assignment grades for the first six weeks of the semester. These two groups had to solve related problem pairs in the opposite order relative to each other with no intervening problems. The study demonstrated learning and problem-solving transfer by considering time to completion, the number of hints requested and the number of incorrect responses given. The group of students who were prepared by a prior related problem solved a related follow-up problem in about 14 per cent less time, on an average, compared to an unprepared group on that problem. Furthermore, the prepared group requested 15 per cent fewer hints and made about 11 per cent fewer errors than the unprepared group.



Claire Masson
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